emperor would ‘even go so far as to [make an] attempt [on] my life?’

Bairam was a powerful man, and Shamsuddin did not take his melodramatic allegations lightly. He went to Bairam with all his sons and relatives and swore ‘solemn oaths’ of allegiance – he had never spoken ill of the regent, he never would. Finally, Bairam Khan ‘came to his senses’.[58]

The saga was not yet ended, however. Having complained to Maham and terrified Shamsuddin, Bairam decided to punish Akbar. He confiscated the boy’s beloved elephants, distributing the imperial herd among his own men.

Akbar said nothing, and Abul Fazl can’t believe it. ‘Good God! What width of capacity! And what gentleness!’ Not only did the padishah not protest his deprivation, he even rewarded his regent a few months later, marrying him to his cousin, Salima.

Poor Akbar. Was it the loss of his elephants that hurt more, or the realization that in Bairam Khan, now his brother-in-law, he was stuck with a tutor he could neither evade nor dismiss?

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And poor Abul Fazl, too, anguished on his emperor’s behalf. Few biographers, even fewer biographers of pre-modern monarchs, can have written at such length, in such detail, and with such feeling for their subjects as Abul Fazl of Akbar. And yet, though the *Akbarnama* and the *Ain-i-Akbari* deliver, between them, such plentiful detail about Akbar’s life and reign, from the founding myth of Alanqoa to what he fed his best elephants (rice cooked with chillies and cloves was part of the menu), it is maddeningly difficult to get an unhindered view of Akbar himself, wrapped as he is in the blinding embrace of Abul Fazl’s adoration.

Only occasionally can you see him in flesh and blood: a child afraid of the dark, a boy missing his mother, an adolescent in a rage. Now, in the third year of his reign, another glimpse of his character emerges: he was deeply uncomfortable with homosexual love.

Specifically, of the love that Ali Quli Shaibani, the brilliant Uzbek warrior who stole Hemu’s artillery and held his place against Hemu’s elephants, espoused for a beautiful flirt of a man called Shahim Beg.

Ali Quli was one of the great warlords of his age.[59] His role in Panipat was second only to that of the anonymous arrow that blinded Hemu (and